

School Committee Meeting Notes - November 2, 2020 - 6 PM

Mayor - calls meeting to order at 6:04 PM

Member Van der Kloot - Roll Call - 7-0

Salute the Flag

Mayor - Approval of minutes - Motion for approval?

Motion for approval by Member Ruseau, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call - 7-0 - minutes are approved

Mayor - approval of bills/transfer of funds/payrolls?

Member Graham - Did we not receive them?

Mayor - Dr. Edouard-Vincent?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - No updated ones, with our meetings being back to back. The next meeting they will be included in your packet

Mayor - Report of Secretary

Member Van der Kloot - I did go to the school to sign the bills, however I did not see any bills for food service? I'll hold that question until later in the meeting.

Mayor - Report of committees - none

Mayor - Community participation?

Member Ruseau - Yes there is...**Questions from the Public:**

Chris K - I've heard from Ms. Simpson at Curriculum Night - no substitute was found - Ms. Khan will let me know when it's posted? Network of math teachers? 3 months of no teacher

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Not sure if Ms. Khan is on the call - I can get the information regarding that particular position. Per Mr. D'Alleva - the position was posted Oct 15th - we haven't

received any applicants at this time. If Chris K has a network, please reach out to Jeanine Camuso in the school personnel office.

Member Van der Kloot - clarify then? How is class covered now?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Ms. Khan is covering it

Mayor - we can get back to that question via email

Jim Donovan - MPS - apple laptops for teachers - chrome books for students

Cost of laptops?

Grant Money used?

Funding Source FY20/21 Grant?

Could funds have been used to improve wifi at MHS?

Could funds have been used for remote learning?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - If you could please forward those specific questions to me - we explored many funding sources, so I want to provide you with the proper information

Member McLaughlin - All teachers for MAC books?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - yes

Member. McLaughlin - It would be appreciated if the responses to his questions could be copied to us and inform the community as well

Member Van der Kloot - I think we all received an email regarding a change in specialists?

Mayor - I'm sorry. That item is not on the agenda.

Member McLaughlin - there was a request that we put it on the agenda, maybe we can put it on the next meeting agenda

Mayor - I believe Asst Superintendent Galusi responded to it yesterday

Member McLaughlin - Yes, well there was more than one email regarding that question

Mayor - Superintendent Remarks

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Good Evening. We were pleased to welcome our 5th graders back to in school learning today. Despite the masks, I could see the light of excitement in the student's eyes. I can say the same for the teachers and staff. With this addition, Medford is proud that K-6 is able to participate safely with in school learning. Today was a big day, as we also reopened the doors to Kids Corner! This service provides our teachers and staff with daycare assistance. By Wednesday, we will open a brand new extension of Kids Corner with Kids Corner Senior which will provide older students to be in the care of adults during remote school days. Today, I spent time this morning visiting the Columbus School. Mr. Plati was dancing a jig with his students. His enthusiasm was contagious and it really just filled my bucket.

Our goal has always been to get our kids back into school. Our students need it, not only for their academics but also for their social/emotional well being. We have moved forward cautiously and methodically. We know this has been hard on our families, but first and foremost, we had to provide safe and healthy learning environments for both our students and staff. With Medford now in the red, our community must remain vigilant in order for our students to be able to stay in school. I urge you to continue abiding by the MPS seven-steps to COVID-19 prevention that include: Masks, Distancing, Wash Hands, Stay at Home if you don't feel well, Notify your school if you test positive, Be Informed and get a flu shot.

While we are very happy to see our K-6 students in school, we do realize that the pace of implementing in-person instruction has been particularly frustrating for our high school community, especially our seniors, both in our comprehensive high school, as well as, the vocational technical high school. The frustration is no doubt exacerbated by the uncertain timeline we have for returning to widespread in-person learning at our flagship school. Our work to repair and improve our HVAC systems at Medford High School is ongoing with three HVAC vendors in Building C and vocational areas on a daily basis. Later this week, we will have greater clarity to what the timeline might be for a return to in-person learning for 7th and 8th grades. The High School update will follow shortly thereafter.

Just a Reminder! Tomorrow is Election Day, so there will be no in- school or remote learning. . Additionally, next Wednesday, November 11th is Veterans Day, and there will be no in-school or remote learning taking place on that date as well.

Last Thursday, Mayor Lungo-Koehn and myself were invited to participate in a zoom press conference, along with Mayor Curtatone and Superintendent Skipper of Somerville, as Tufts

University announced the launch of an innovative Covid-19 testing program for PK-12 schools. This partnership eventually will bring Covid-19 surveillance testing to our public schools, using a new, more efficient pooled testing method developed by Tufts in collaboration with the Broad Institute of MIT and Harvard. This testing will provide testing for our school community at approximately one-third of the cost of individual testing. We are grateful for the continued assistance and support that has been provided to us by Tufts University and President Anthony Monaco during the pandemic. I'd like to extend my thanks to Chris Zador from Tufts, as well as, Toni Wray and MaryAnn O'Connor.

Last month on The Dash, a national podcast, Richard Trotta, the director of the Center for Citizenship and Social Responsibility, was interviewed about CCSR, the after school program that focuses on leadership skills and the merits of project-based learning. Additionally, CCSR has released a calendar for November which is Gratitude Month. I have enclosed a copy in your file folders.

I would like to welcome Sandy Occil, as the Interim Director at the West Medford Community Center. Sandy is a graduate of St. Clements High School, and has an extensive background in non profit organizations. This Friday, November 6th, the West Medford Community Center along with Terry Carter will host a discussion about Covid and the Medford Public Schools. Terry will moderate a discussion that will include Ms. Stacey Schulman, our Director of Clinical Services and Guidance, School Committee Member Melanie McLaughlin, and myself. Additionally, there will be a parent on the panel. We hope you will join with us during this zoom event Friday night at 8 PM.

Member McLaughlin - Point of information, I believe there will be a teacher on the panel as well

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I believe that Terry said the panel was complete, but I will double check with him

Thanks to Toni Wray & MaryAnn O'Connor, they will be hosting a zoom information session for our multilingual families, this Thursday, November 5, 2020 at 6 PM.

Member McLaughlin - Point of information, thank you to Toni and MaryAnn for doing this. How will our families be alerted about this event? Will it be shared on the Talking Points App?

Toni Wray - We are very excited about hosting this event. I will be leaning on Paul Teixeira and his staff to get the information out to the families.

Member McLaughlin - Thank you. I will reach out to him as well

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - In closing, I would like to take this opportunity to wish our Hindu families and friends a Happy Diwali Day, which begins November 14th, and is part of a five day holiday celebration. Diwali Day signifies the victory of: Light over darkness, Good over evil, Knowledge over ignorance & Hope over despair. Truly things we can all benefit from in our day to day lives.

Mayor - Thank you Dr. Edouard-Vincent. And now we will hear from Toni Wray and MaryAnn O'Connor about Medford's Covid Update

Ms. O'Connor - I want to reiterate that people who are identified as close contacts that they need to quarantine - If you get tested, stay home until you receive the test results - Today, Governor Baker issued new orders. Medford is a high risk community as we are red right now - Unfortunately our cases are climbing just like the state, and we will be red again this week - So if we are red for 3 weeks = higher risk - so everyone please wear a mask! Regarding the potential pool testing, very exciting, very cutting edge and we need to make this happen. There are many details we still need to work out, and we will want parent input as well - this could be very innovative and really good for our schools and our community. There will be more to come on that

Member McLaughlin - Can you please explain what pool testing is all about?

Ms. O'Connor - pool testing allows us, at a much less costly way, to pool test students in cohort groups. They only have to run that one sample - if you have a positive pool, you retest each student in that cohort and see who is actually positive

Member McLaughlin - Can you clarify the red designation?

Ms. O'Connor - Yes, I do understand the confusion. They are saying 4 weeks per DESE and the Governor, but they are stressing the point is keeping the kids in school - so unless the outbreaks are happening in the schools, schools should remain in session. In Medford, our outbreaks are in the form of community contact. The students who have tested positive are those on remote. Transmissions are not happening in schools. Students that are in school are being reminded to wear their masks, social distance and keep up with hand washing, while remote students aren't receiving that positive reinforcement.

Member Graham -Regarding contact tracing within schools = 100% compliance?

Ms. O'Connor - it is often hard to have some people call us back, but often we find it is a language issue - so there is no outright non compliance

Ms. Wray - The school nurses assist the BOH in obtaining a translator and the nurse will stay on the call as well. Remote students have tested positive and this tends to be consistent across the state - Reminder - mandated flu vaccines - children need to be vaccinated. Also, just a reminder, if students are not Medford residents who may want to utilize the Kids Corner Sr. Division, the nurses office will require an immunization form copy and medical update - I am very grateful for parents who are getting their children immunized

Mayor - Report on MPS Progress

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - a continuation of my report from last week. We have had some coverage challenges - supervisory capacity is down - we are addressing these with redeployment of staff and filling vacancies as quickly as we can - we are monitoring the transmission rate in community - we have no plan at this time, to scale back school at this time - I just received an updated air quality report and I will sent to SC and post it to website. We have made improvements in areas of MHS and we are spot checking at other schools at this point. The new reports that will be posted reference the McGlynn, Andrews and MHS. There is one area still in question at the McGlynn Middle School side, and we are waiting for parts. I will be receiving status updates from all vendors doing work on Wednesday. Once I receive these, we can adjust timelines. Again we are awaiting parts to arrive, while also exploring relationships with other vendors to reduce the wait. Of course, we will continue to circulate these reports throughout the community. We also plan to provide a sustainable program for our air quality. Please note that we have made all of the reports available since September. Also, the updates are made multiple times a week, and we continue to publish them to stay transparent

Mayor - Thank you

Member Ruseau - I do have questions from the community...

Mayor - Let me take questions from the school committee first

Member McLaughlin - Thank you for all the work you've been doing. Since you have arrived, you have been working constantly. Is the 4.0 per hour rate - - -- is that a legal requirement? Or is it an agreement, a standard or a best practice?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - There are no legal requirements. The range of 4-6 is generally the industry standard - What is required is often a 2.0 for a non-high traffic office. There is no

statute or regulation - it was important for the district and the agreement we made with the largest bargaining unit for safety for all.

Member McLaughlin - I am glad to hear that there is no intention to scale back the hybrid, but in reality, we have scaled back. Our Seniors were expected back Oct 19th, but that has not happened. Our students are in despair that they can't come into school - Dr. Cushing & Mr. D'Alleva ran a Q & A which was helpful - would be great if students could host another one, student led. David you have certainly been baptized by fire!

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - the report I have will have a MHS update on it - I haven't been able to read through it yet - Engineers have given me some optimism - there is a light at end of tunnel - Our challenges have been; Our Metrics, Coverage & Staffing Issues & the MHS/MVTHS HVAC issues. With our (CoHort A), we will need to juggle, when we add MHS/MVTHS students into the building. We are doing everything we can for the Voke and 11th and 12th students and we are hopeful that we will be able to put together a more specific timeline

Mayor - So grades 7-12 will be updated with a timeline?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Yes, eventually a more specific timeline for some portion of those grade levels

Member Ruseau - We have 4 emails from the community...*Questions from the Community*

Melissa Maywailt - 6th grader hybrid days - on line for all his classes - defeats purpose of being in school -

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - We have had a lot of internal dialogue about this. We have some challenges to address, no question.

Jaime Taylor - Why aren't teachers being told ahead of time for testing? Why aren't we getting earlier notifications for returning to school? Why is testing also short notice?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Please note that we have said all along that our staff is always welcome in our buildings. Additionally, no staff members should be surprised when the Superintendent announces another grade level entering school. That is our goal...to get the students in school. It is not accurate that there is short notice regarding testing. Testing is open to all staff every week. We are trying to get students in as soon as possible, so sometimes it will be short notice - Given the holidays coming up - district sponsored testing will be done on different days and email notifications will go out with the new day and times.

Jaime Taylor - I'm a 6th grade teacher, but teaching out of a 7th grade room...Will I be moved again? And teachers are getting this information with very little notice ...

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Again, our priority is our students, so timelines are sometimes short. There is definitely a lot of shuffling going on and we are extremely grateful to all the teachers. We know there will be times when there is a need for a quick classroom set up

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - We must put our children first - seeing their excitement to be inside the building - I'll put our 7th and 8th grades on notice - if we need to re-deploy our custodians to help with moving, we will do so. Our goal is, especially with all the work that's being done by the engineers, to get our grades back into their original spaces

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Principals can release staff to set up classrooms - I don't want to minimize the work to set up the classroom but during a pandemic, we need to adjust to different timelines - work is coming and it is necessary work - people should feel free to go into the schools whenever they want

Jaime Taylor - Is it true there are no more masks breaks during the day?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - yes there are mask breaks

Jaime Taylor - We have no substitutes and all of our paras covering classes

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - We made remote accommodations for teachers -but yes coverage is a significant issue and we need to overcome it

Erica Hunt - What about the families that have chosen remote and then want to go back to in school? Will there be room in the schools?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Yes, we will be able to do so

Mayor - I believe her question was, do they have the ability to switch?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy- at this point, it would take a lot of switching for it to become a problem - maybe we'd have to relook at it in the spring - we are monitoring hybrid to remote - in case remotes get too full - but we are keeping it on the radar

Carina - What about our high school students that are not Seniors? How are they being checked in on?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Our assistant principals and teachers are very aware of this and have continued relationship building with the students on a daily basis. SEL toll is being taken on all of our students. It's our high priority from the Superintendent on down.

Member Ruseau - The use of administrators to fill in where needed. Finding subs in normal times was difficult -- so if we already rely on Admin for K-6 - do we have a plan if we don't have enough adults as we add in more grades?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - classes have moved temporarily remote due to not having enough adult coverage - that is the ultimate backstop - we still believe that students do better being in school - we also must fill vacancies and looking at temporary workers and some temporary staff workers coming on within the next week - creative with the CARES act funding, we continue to look into different funding - multifaceted approach to get our students in school - it's a challenge we have to live with - students belong in school

Member Ruseau - **Email from Nadine Merretti** - It is November 2nd and we still don't have an update on how many classrooms are available at MHS and what about a Vocational update?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - MHS and MVTHS is absolutely a priority and the reports are just coming in and some areas of the Voke wing will be available - but again, it will be somewhat of a domino effect - space / staff / etc - hopeful to have a more specific timeline next week - there's an urgency to get the students back into the schools - it's shared by the union, school committee, administration and staff

Member Ruseau - **Email from Sharon Hays** - where can parents find information on hybrid and remote class sizes?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Specific questions on that should be referred to the principals or to Dr. Cushing or Ms. Galusi

Mayor - Report on alternative learning spaces with Dr. Cushing and Principal Tucci

Dr. Cushing - Mr. Tucci & Mr. Downs have done a tremendous job to prepare their schools and are very organized to receive their students. Mr. Tucci has a little more outdoor space with a path behind the McGlynn - He has set up 3 outdoor classrooms, right at the first floor so there is access for electricity purposes. We have utilized our extra furniture, due to reducing class sizes. There are 3 LCD carts and one smart board so students can access the internet. I want to commend Mr. Tucci and his staff for this outdoor space. We would like to continue this in a post covid environment - Andrews didn't have the space/opportunity to do this

Mayor - Presentation of Integrated Camera Use at Roberts with Ms. Galusi, Mr. Johnson and Mr. O'Brien

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - At your September 30th school committee meeting you accepted a donation for the Roberts which they utilized to purchase webcams for all teachers at the Roberts Mr. Johnson and Mr. O'Brien started training the teachers right away - Webcams audio and visual tool - used both in class and remote - attached to teacher computers so sound is projected nicely & the LCD projector - since this donation, the Roberts administration have assisted the rest of the district on how to use the webcams - As you will see from the photos, the webcams situated in classroom and the next photo shows another view of students in class and in remote - for all K-5 classrooms. The webcams are used 100% for morning meeting activities - both in the classroom and at home - hyperlinks to this presentation are available and the Pledge of Allegiance - will be posted to the website - music instruction DESE prefers remote instruction - so webcams can assist

Member Van der Kloot - Can you please clarify the grade levels that the webcams are being used for?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - K-5 - all levels - with grades 3, 4 & 5 - slow transition

Dr. Cushing - 6th grade is piloting livestream for their classes as well

Member Graham - We have purchased these cameras for all teachers? And have they arrived or are we awaiting delivery?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - currently all teachers and specialists have a webcam, as well as related service teachers - For those teachers who may not have received one, they should have one by Thursday

Member Graham - connects to desktop - has it been tested seamlessly with MAC books? What is happening to desktops?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - we did trials with laptop and a MAC book - worked equally as well

Dr. Cushing - not going to remove desktops at this time - they are 9 years old - but gives our teachers some flexibility

Member Graham - at middle school level - difficult for remote kids to hear any discussions in the classes

Dr. Cushing - I hadn't heard that but will check into it - there are other microphones we can look into if needed - and we are field testing some solutions too -

Member Graham - I think we need to look into microphones - We don't want this to become an equity issue as we'll have them anyway - survey the teachers and survey the kids as well - to get the information they need - at the elementary level - can you provide the timeline? phasing in with some consistency - could you provide a report next time as to where we are in the various classrooms?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - I can do that

Mayor - Report on MPS Food Services from Mr. Murphy

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - food services has been significantly affected - there are live issues that we still need to resolve as we scale up with in person instruction - we have a plan in place that is being executed well, but there are issues that require some ironing out - some schools require coverage, or logistics - so I may have to get back to you with some answers - upon closure, school stopped and Y stepped in providing food service - Sept 28th school began and our food services began again - 3rd week - schools started hot meals - slow start with participation but is ramping up - lunch and breakfast - discrepancy in comparison to last year obviously - proximity is a challenge for Malden Y and Columbus School - trying to address that - low participation at MHS due to low class sizes at MHS right now - inconsistency out of DESE - districts were told to have students eat at desks - we are still looking if we can shift 2 lunches to 3 - coverage challenges - is another challenge coming down the pike -we are looking at our pick up spots at each school - We need safe, efficient spots for pick up for parents and doesn't leave staff out in the cold - Participation was traditionally in the 40's - we have to look at the variety offered and generate interest with students & families for more robust participation - Member Van der Kloot noted there were few bills for food services, but I will get them to you for the next meeting.

Member McLaughlin - Thank you for the report - I'm bringing up a few questions: what about some members of our community who are finding it difficult to pick up lunches due to their schedules? What about members of our community who go remote due to close contact/have covid - how can distributions be done for them? Deliveries? Bulk pickups?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - You bring up important questions - whether we should do bulk pickups? How would meals last over time? Maybe remote outlets? Can we combine both ideas? Bulk package at remote outlets? How do we partner with other organizations? Malden Y for example as it might be the best way to deliver the service - I'll take a closer look at that

Member McLaughlin - I'm willing to help - I have a real concern with those families being sent home for a covid reason. They need us to get food to them - do you want to give a timeline?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Our next step would be to meet with our partners to see what their capacities are? I hope to do that within the course of the next week - maybe I could report back, not at the next meeting, but at the following meeting.

Mayor - Mr. Murphy, please feel free to reach out to Syrah McGiven on the city side, as she might be able to assist you

Mayor - Any communications? Hearing and seeing none. Any new business? Hearing and seeing none.

Mayor - Condolences to the family of Lillian Tonello

Motion to adjourn by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call 7-0

Mayor - Meeting adjourned at 8:11 PM - our next regular meeting is November 16th